

Why Toronto can't seem to build enough housing*

An analysis of apartment construction in Toronto

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As the city of Toronto continues to expand, it demands increasing amounts of housing, which are not being met currently, leaving Toronto in a housing crisis. Our analysis of Toronto apartment construction data compares activity across four distinct periods: pre-war, post-war, end of century, and contemporary. Our findings show a significant decline in construction since the post-war boom, along with a shift towards vertical expansion in the downtown. We argue that the city is not likely to be able to scale housing as quickly as it has in the past, and that other mechanisms will need to be considered to solve the crisis.

1 Introduction

Following World War II, Toronto experienced a period of prosperity and rapid development (McGillivray and Howarth 2026). Supported by affordable housing policies, the city saw a huge amount of construction, as demand for new housing exploded. The city grew rapidly, and became the largest city in Canada in 1976 (McGillivray and Howarth 2026): this represents the peak of investments in affordable housing (CCHR 2022). However, the rapid construction of housing of the post-war boom has not been matched in the 21st century. As housing construction stagnated and declined in the late 20th century, Toronto became the victim of a significant housing crisis. Today, Toronto consistently has a higher rate of low-income households than the rest of Canada or Ontario (Toronto 2026).

In this analysis, we aim to explain the housing crisis, via a history of Toronto's housing development, from 1900 to 2020. We focus on the construction of apartment buildings using data from Open Data Toronto (RentSafeTO 2026), and track their construction over time, as well as their locations and sizes.

*Code and data are available at: <https://github.com/baleinegris/TorontoHousingAnalysis>.

Through data visualization on the construction of apartment buildings in Toronto, we find that modern efforts by the city are bearing modest fruit, but not nearly to the extent that they would need to in order to meet demand. We argue that the city is not likely to be able to scale housing as quickly as it has in the past, and that other mechanisms will need to be considered by the city, provincial, and federal government to find a solution to this housing crisis.

The remainder of the paper is structured as follows. In Section 2, we describe the dataset, its collection, and our cleaning process. In Section 3, we present our findings on the amount of construction, the types of buildings constructed, and their locations. Finally, in Section 4, we summarize our findings, discuss their implications for the city of Toronto, identify limitations, and suggest avenues for future research.

2 Data

2.1 Overview

For our analysis, we use the Python programming language (Foundation 2026), the matplotlib plotting library (Hunter 2007), and the contextily library for plotting geospatial data (Arribas-Bel 2023). We also use the pandas library for data manipulation (McKinney 2010), and geopandas for geospatial data manipulation (Jordahl et al. 2020).

We use the Apartment Building Evaluation dataset from Open Data Toronto (RentSafeTO 2026), obtained through the CKAN API (Association 2005). This dataset contains information from apartment inspections for buildings registered in RentSafeTO: Apartment Building Standards. RentSafeTO is a bylaw enforcement program founded by the city of Toronto in 2017, and includes all buildings with three or more storeys and 10 or more units. Inspections must occur at least once every two years. The dataset includes information from the inspections themselves, as well as information about the building itself. The inspection method changed in 2023, and so the dataset is downloaded in two parts. For our analysis, we focus only on the information about the building, and not the details of the inspections.

2.2 Measurement

Inspections are conducted by the city each year. A list is made of all buildings requiring an evaluation, the building receives a notice, and a bylaw enforcement officer is assigned to inspect the building. On the date of the inspection, the officer visits the building, photographing and documenting the state of the building manually. The details of the inspection are then given to the building, who is required to share them with tenants, as well as being added to the public dataset. As such, there is not ethical concern with using this data, as it is already required to be public.

2.3 Cleaning

As mentioned, we did not include information about the inspections themselves. For each building, we kept only the most recent inspection, and then dropped all columns related to the inspection. We kept the following columns:

- **RSN**: a unique identifier for each building
- **units**: the number of units in the building
- **storeys**: the number of storeys in the building
- **year_built**: the year the building was built
- **latitude**: the latitude of the building
- **longitude**: the longitude of the building

Additionally, we only included buildings built between 1900 and 2020. We justify this decision in two ways: firstly, there are very few buildings built prior to 1900, and so their inclusion would not add to our analysis. Secondly, there appears to be a lag between the time when a building is constructed and its addition to the dataset. This is likely because the building must be registered in RentSafeTO, and then inspected at least once before it is added to the dataset. As such, we exclude buildings built after 2020, as the data appears to be incomplete. After cleaning, we are left with 3464 buildings in our dataset.

3 Results

3.1 Gross Units Built

Studying the distribution of buildings constructed by year (Figure 1), we notice four distinct periods of construction. In the early 1900s (1900-1945), we see minimal construction. Then, following World War II, we see a huge boom, peaking in the 70s. From the 80s to the early 2000s, we see a significant decline in construction, with construction between 1995 and 2005 being lower than anything since 1950. Finally, we see a modest but persistent increase in construction since the 2000s.

This data seems to paint a grim picture: current levels of construction are far lower than they have been historically. While the increase in construction since 2000 is promising, it is not nearly enough to match the population growth of the city. The population growth rate of Toronto has consistently been higher than the national average, and it now has over 7 million people (“The Toronto Region’s Population Has Topped 7 Million. Here Is What You Need to Know” 2025). Why has the city not been able to scale up apartment construction, as it did in the 50s? To answer this question, we examined the types and locations of new apartment buildings being constructed today.

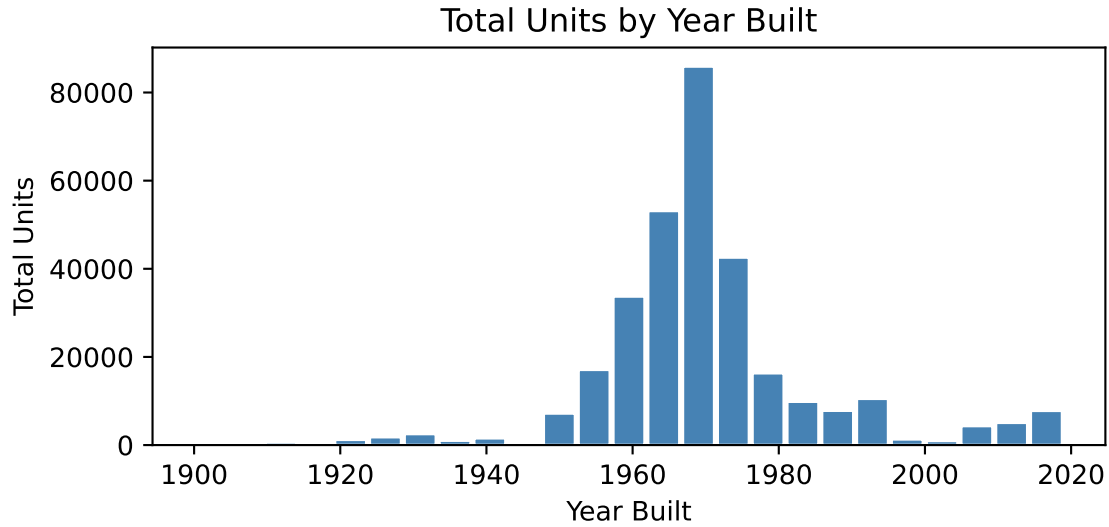


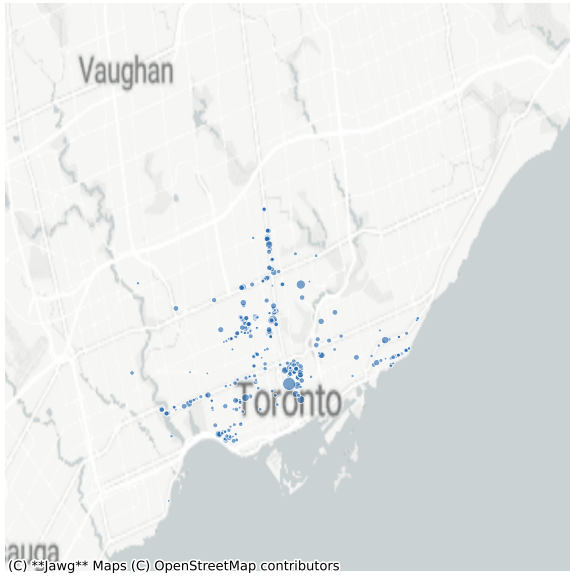
Figure 1: Total Units by Year Built

3.2 Four Eras of Construction

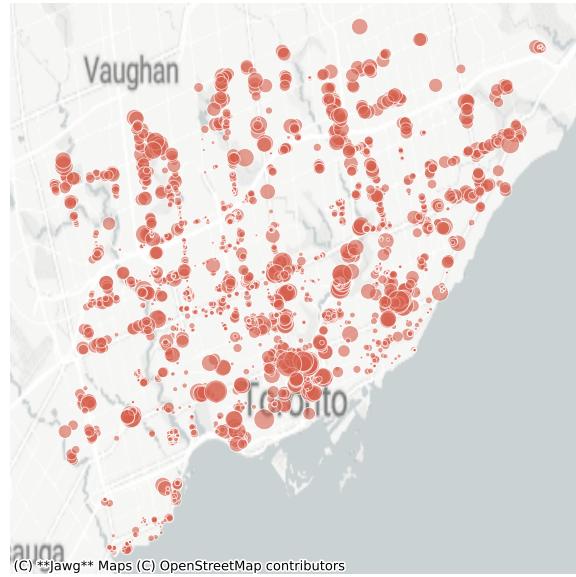
Examining the location and size of construction, and stratifying by construction era, a clearer story emerges (Figure 2), and it is one of urban sprawl. Starting off in the Pre-War era, we see construction of small apartments focused in the downtown. In the Post-War boom, we see a huge explosion of mid-sized apartments, stretching out into the suburbs. This massive growth was made possible by the availability of greenfield around the city, which allowed for horizontal expansion. Then, in the End of Century period, we see the decline in construction we noticed in Figure 1. Finally, in the Contemporary period, we see a focus on the construction of a small number of large apartments, generally focused in the downtown.

Plotting the average number of storeys in new buildings, we see that in the modern period there is a trend towards taller buildings with more units (Figure 3). This indicates a shift from horizontal expansion to vertical expansion, a trend that is echoed in the urban cycle of many cities globally (Zambon et al. 2019). We hypothesize that the decline of suburban construction and the shift towards vertical expansion is due to an increasing scarcity of greenfield around the city after the urban sprawl of the post-war boom. Vertical expansion allows more the city to house more people in the same land footprint.

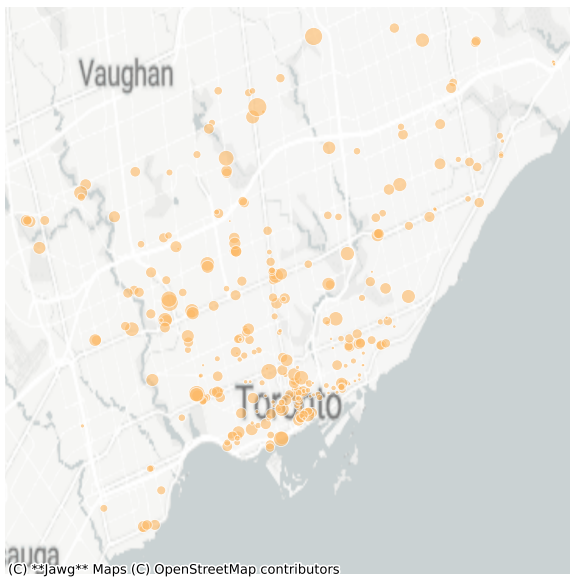
Hence, Figure 2 goes a long way in explaining why the city of Toronto has not been able to build at the rate of the post-war boom: horizontal expansion is not as viable as it was in the 50s, as available land becomes increasingly scarce. The city is now forced to build vertically, which brings with it many new issues.



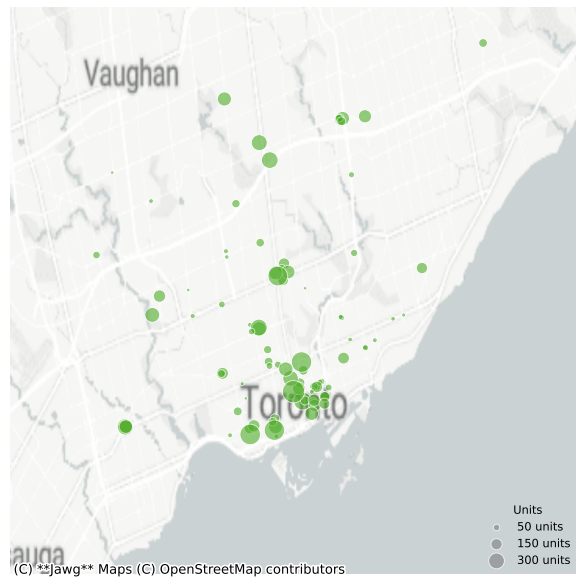
(a) Pre-War (1900-1945)



(b) Post-War (1945-1979)



(c) End of Century (1980-1999)



(d) Modern (2000-2020)

Figure 2: Residential buildings in Toronto by construction era. Bubble size reflects number of units.

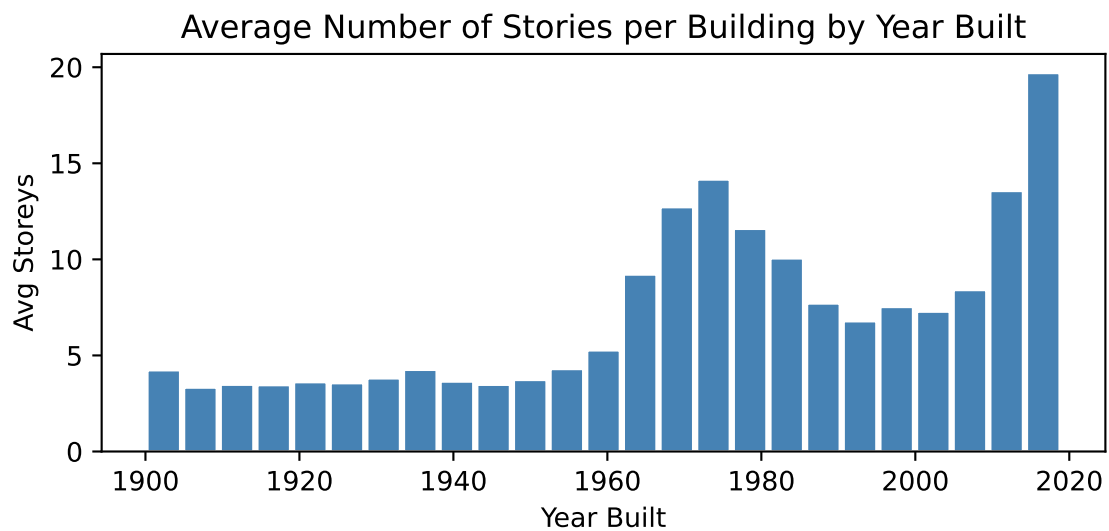


Figure 3: Average Number of Stories per Building by Year Built

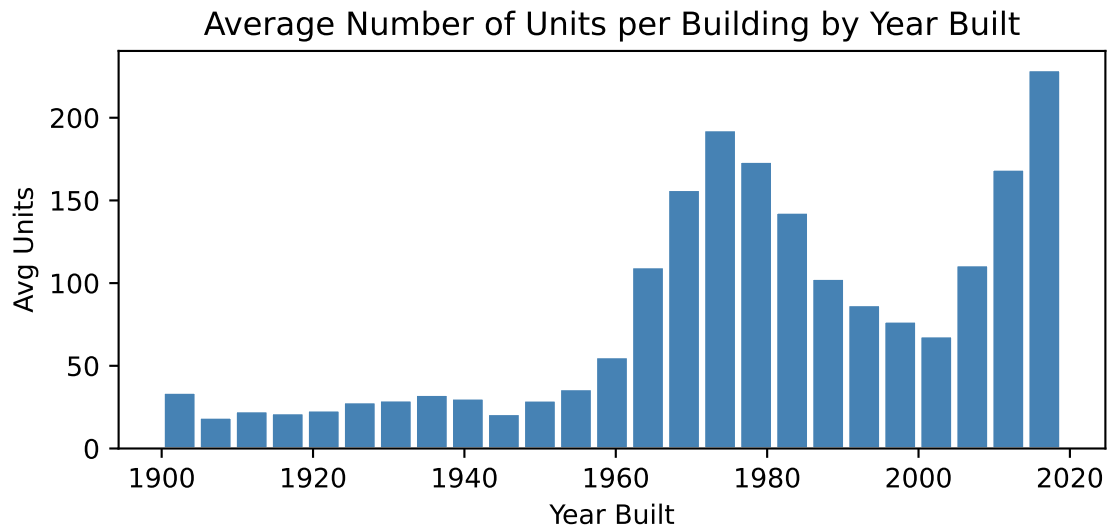


Figure 4: Average Number of Units per Building by Year Built

4 Limitations and Conclusion

As the city of Toronto nears the limits of its horizontal growth, it struggles to adapt to vertical expansion, as witnessed by the housing crisis and the city's inability to address it. Simply using the strategies that worked in the post-war boom will no longer be sufficient to solve the crisis, and the city will need to consider other mechanisms to address the issue, such as reducing regulatory hurdles to construction. It appears that the city is beginning to make progress in this direction, as seen by the modest increase in housing since the 2000s, focused in vertical expansion in the downtown. However, whether this will be sufficient to meet increasing demand remains dubious. In 2022 and 2023, Toronto has the highest gross increase in population of any city in North America (Clayton 2024), and the construction doesn't reflect this growth.

This analysis is limited by several factors. Firstly, the dataset only includes buildings with three or more storeys, and 10 or more units. This excludes the construction of single-family homes, as well as small apartments, from our analysis. If there has been significant increase in their construction, our analysis may be overly pessimistic about modern construction. Finally, the dataset only included construction in Toronto, and not in the surrounding GTA and satellite cities, which have experienced significant growth.

Hence, future research should compare the growth of smaller satellite cities around Toronto (such as Mississauga, Brampton, Vaughan...), as well as other cities in Ontario or Canada more broadly to see if they are picking up the slack. Future work can also explore the construction of smaller apartments and homes, to study any trends in their construction.

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